



The Expat Dialect Cheat-Sheet

25 real words & phrases that change meaning by country

False friends 4 entries



ALL DIALECTS

embarazada

"Pregnant" — not "embarrassed"

I'm embarrassed → "Tengo vergüenza"



MEXICO

caliente

"Soy caliente" = I'm horny — not "I'm hot"

I'm hot (temperature) → "Tengo calor"



SPAIN

bizarro

"Brave, valiant" — not "bizarre"

"Bizarre" → "extraño"



MEXICO

macho

"Male" (an animal) — not the attitude

The attitude → "machista"

Danger zone 1 entry



SPAIN → MEXICO

coger

Spain: "to take / catch" · Mexico: vulgar — avoid it

In Mexico say "agarrar" instead

"Cool" — 3 countries, 3 words 3 entries

HOW TO SAY "COOL"



Spain

guay — cool



Mexico

chido — cool



Argentina

copado — cool

Money — nobody says "dinero" 3 entries

WHAT PEOPLE ACTUALLY SAY



Spain

pasta — money



Mexico

lana — money



Argentina

guita — money

Time — four different clocks 4 entries

HOW TO SAY "RIGHT NOW"



Mexico

ahorita — now ... or maybe never



Spain

ahora mismo — right now



Argentina

al toque — right away



Chile

al tiro — right now

■ Untranslatable 3 entries

 SPAIN

sobremesa

The chat that lingers at the table after a meal
English has no word for it

 ARGENTINA

fiaca

Can't-be-bothered laziness
"Me da fiaca" = I really can't be bothered

 MEXICO

empalagarse

To be sick of too much sweetness
Said after one bite of cake too many

■ Greetings — say hello like a local 4 entries

HOW TO SAY "HELLO"

 Spain **¡Buenas!** — hello (any hour)

 Mexico **¿Qué onda?** — what's up?

 Argentina **¿Qué hacés?** — how's it going?

 Colombia **¿Qué más?** — what's up?

■ The "you" problem 3 entries

THE WORD THAT GIVES YOU AWAY

 Argentina **vos** — "you" — replaces tú

 Spain **vosotros** — "you all" (Spain only)

 Mexico **ustedes** — "you all" (Latin America)